others.[37] The dynamics of sibling rivalry are manifested in numerous myths in addition to the *Ramayana*, for instance in the stories of Cain and Abel, King Lear and the TV series *Succession*. Entire nations – like the Jewish people – may base their identity on the claim that 'we are Father's favourite children'.

The second major plotline of the *Ramayana* focuses on the romantic triangle formed by Prince Rama, his lover, Sita, and the demon-king Ravana, who kidnaps Sita. 'Boy meets girl' and 'boy fights boy over girl' are also biological dramas that have been enacted by countless mammals, birds, reptiles and fish for hundreds of millions of years. We are mesmerised by these stories because understanding them has been essential for our ancestors' survival. Human storytellers like Homer, Shakespeare and Valmiki – the purported author of the *Ramayana* – have displayed an amazing capacity to elaborate on the biological dramas, but even the greatest poetical narratives usually copy their basic plotline from the handbook of evolution.

A third theme recurring in the *Ramayana* is the tension between purity and impurity, with Sita being the paragon of purity in Hindu culture. The cultural obsession with purity originates in the evolutionary struggle to avoid pollution. All animals are torn between the need to try new food and the fear of being poisoned. Evolution therefore equipped animals with both curiosity and the capacity to feel disgust on coming into contact with something toxic or otherwise dangerous.[38] Politicians and prophets have learned how to manipulate these disgust mechanisms. In nationalist and religious myths, countries or churches are depicted as a biological body in danger of being polluted by impure intruders. For centuries bigots have often said that ethnic and religious minorities spread diseases,[39] that LGBTQ people are a source of pollution,[40] or that women are impure.[41] During the Rwanda genocide of 1994, Hutu propaganda referred to the Tutsis as cockroaches. The Nazis compared Jews to rats. Experiments have shown that chimpanzees, too, react with disgust to images of unfamiliar chimpanzees from another band.[42]

Perhaps in no other culture was the biological drama of 'purity versus impurity' carried to greater extremes than in traditional Hinduism. It constructed an intersubjective system of castes ranked by their supposed level of purity, with the pure Brahmins at the top and the allegedly impure